



**VISHNU ZENDE, 37**  
**Railway Announcer LOCATION: CST**

## “Our hearts sank when he (terrorist) stood up, saw us and fired”

It was just another round of duty for CST announcer Vishnu Zende but thanks to his presence of mind, thousands of lives were saved on Mumbai's night of horror.

At around 10 p.m. on the night of November 26, Zende heard a loud explosion and sensed that something was wrong at the station. He looked out of his cabin and saw commuters fleeing from the express platforms towards the main station area. Many were hurt and had blood all over them. Quick to act, he got in touch with the Rapid Action Force and Government Railway Police manning the station to rush to the mainline section. Two trains were approaching the station. He picked up the microphone and announced: “*Kripiya saare yaatri platform number one, gate number one se nikal jaiye* (Please leave the station through platform No. 1 from Gate No. 1)”, repeatedly for 30 minutes. “Since this is next to the main road, I thought it was best,” recalls Zende. Lost in the call of duty, Zende and two other operators, who were with him in the cabin, did not realise that their lives were also in danger.

“We called up our families to say we were safe when we were not. The terrorists could

have easily seen us,” says the intrepid Zende.

Later, when the two alleged terrorists came towards the main station area and opened fire again, the trio kept a constant vigil on them. They used cardboard to cover the glass front and kept peeping out through a small gap. “They came and stood right before our cabin. One of them had a bag in front and one on his back. He came inside the station and reloaded his gun,” recounts Zende. They were in constant touch with family and relatives to gauge the situation. At some point of time one of the terrorist who was standing below their cabin looked up at them. “Our hearts sank when he stood just below the building and fired a few rounds,” says Zende. One of the terrorists even fired a bullet into the glass front of their cabin when one of his colleagues stood up to turn off the lights. They kept informing the higher officials about the developments till 2 a.m.

It was only at 4 a.m. that train services were resumed. But Zende couldn't call it a day. He continued to work as a colleague who had to take over from him in the morning didn't make it to the station. He has no complaints, just grateful he was alive to fill in.